

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 27

MONTANA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Montana's family courts and child-welfare system.

75

MONTANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 148 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 20 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
NOVEMBER 9, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
22 OF 56

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · MONTANA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Montana. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Camisha Sawtelle

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · CHILD ATTORNEY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"She represents a lot of kids in this county. She is not a family lawyer, she is an environmental lawyer. She never stands up for the children. Unless family comes forward and wants the kids, she seems to rally for certain foster parents to keep kids, over family. We have reached out to her over all the abuse allegations, she won't even respond."* FLATHEAD COUNTY

> *"She does not stand up for or advocate for the children. The first week the kids were back with their parents, they were choked. She didn't see anything wrong with it"*

> *"She defamesmy character all the time. She fought tooth and nail for my children to not go with our aunt, who is already a licensed foster home"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/mt-camisha-sawtelle/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Dev Haegele

CPS WORKER · FLATHEAD COUNTY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"She came on the case and the 1st visit she was terrible to us. Then said she was returning the kids to the abusive parents. We are the aunt and uncle to the birth mother."*

> *"CPS worker. She is allowing the kids to stay in an abusive environment. Treats the kinship foster parents extremely bad"*

> *"She lies and put children in harms way all the time"* FLATHEAD

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/mt-dev-haegele/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Hon. Amy Poehling Eddy

JUDGE · FLATHEAD · **4 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Confidential information was handed to the other side."* FLATHEAD COUNTY

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/mt-hon-amy-poehling-eddy/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Jodi Christiansen

CPS WORKER · FLATHEAD COUNTY · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Ahe is the cps supervisor. She neglects to supervise. She lets all the workers under her play God and just goes along with it."* FLATHEAD

> *"Cps supervisor. Lets all the workers under her go rogue and do what they want. Will not return calls."*

> *"She is the CPS supervisor she allows the people under her to go rogue and do whatever they want."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/mt-jodi-christiansen/complaint-packet
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John W. Larson

JUDGE · MISSOULA · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"He was my youth judge when I was a minor as a foster kid . And he was the judge that had my kids in the system when they were taken at birth. And while I was pregnant with my 2nd child they orchestrated a criminal case against me falsely to discredit me when I had my 2nd child. They forced me to sign legal documents so I wouldn't go to prison but they used my false confession to take my kid . And I was all over the news . They removed it from the internet but it was there at one point. This judge never cared about proof . He only cared if cps filed the right paperwork and agreed with everything cps said. And wouldn't let me defend myself."*

> *"Ongoing- Told me I couldn't object this isn't TV and turned to the opposing counsel and said "this is your show, take it away" Denied TOP said it was a "ploy to keep dad from parenting time" denied without being heard. Then turned to opposing council and said "this is your show, take it away""*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/mt-john-w-larson/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MONTANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 75 Montana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
148
75 of 75 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$120,000
median across 33 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
20
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
58.7%
44 of 75 who answered; 38 of 75 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTIES REPRESENTED
75	2.0	75 of 75	22

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Montana families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF MONTANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	51	$15,000	$38,602	$1,968,705
Lost Wages	41	$20,000	$50,433	$2,067,756
Other Court Fees	34	$200	$1,487	$50,543
Therapy / Evaluations	37	$2,000	$5,401	$199,828
Reunification Services	18	$250	$2,078	$37,400
GAL Fees	25	$300	$3,072	$76,800
Asset Loss [1]	31	$17,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (33 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$120,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($17,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost	20	1.7 yrs
Mean months lost	36	3 yrs
Total across all families	1,959	163.2 yrs

04 WHO IS REPORTING · MONTANA

Most families documenting in Montana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	39	52%
Active case: progress being made	11	15%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	7	9%
Case closed: within last 2 years	7	9%
Not provided	6	8%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only	40	53%
Both Family Court and CPS	26	35%
CPS Only	7	9%
Unknown	2	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	23	31%
5 – 10 years	19	25%
3 – 5 years	14	19%
6 months – 1 year	8	11%
Over 10 years	7	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access	22	29%
50/50 Joint	20	27%
Visitation Only	20	27%
Full Custody	7	9%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)	4	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Flathead	17	24%
Yellowstone	12	17%
Missoula	8	11%
Lewis And Clark	4	6%
Cascade	4	6%
Silverbow	3	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	20	27%
High Conflict Divorce	16	21%
Other	13	17%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	12	16%
Other: (Short answer)	5	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — MONTANA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Montana comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *Hurt me and my children destroyed their lives and mine makes them live their abuser who made my son autistic*
>
> — BOBBIE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Due process in family court is a fiction. Our courts are violating the Constitution of the United States and they are shielding those judgements from constitutional scrutiny by invoking state specific statutes and rules to explain their actions. Parental rights have truly been [...]

— MONTANA PARENT · CIARA

MORE VOICES FROM MONTANA

Having to navigate a system where corrupt attorneys who play some sick game with your kids lives and to try and force a protective mother to bend to the will of a dangerous pedophile; a GAL hiding behind a psychologist degree who mocks and insults you and refused to follow the [...]

— MARIAH

Made me lose everything traumatized abused and neglected

— LINDSEY

I told the truth. I reported abuse to protect my sons and I. Now I only get supervised visits at the approval of our abuser.

— CHELSIE

It has destroyed my mental Health. I have PTSD and CPTSD from domestic abuse as well as litigation, financial, and medical abuse. My records were published publicly as were my children's by the Court allowing others to misuse my records and data for further financial harm and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *By endorsing factually impossible recommendations and ignoring documented non-compliance, the current legal process has systematically deprived my children of stability and safety while allowing their developmental milestones to be traded for high-conflict trauma.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

Yellowstone cps and family lass multiplied my abusers power ten fold. It's business as usual.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tore apart my family. Traumatized my kids and lead them to believe I had abandoned them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has absolutely ruined my kids, their relationship with their step dad, who mind you pays all the bills and would hang the moon for them. It has never once made a motion in the best interest of the children, it has all been money moved!

— CALLIE

The system has failed to investigate facts over here. Say the system has rewarded the abuser based off of her hearsay with no evidence. The system has denied any factual evidence to prove her hearsay wrong. The system has not taken any consideration that the kids could be in [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It is totally destroyed the relationship between my child and I they have told him lies about me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The father of my child is the son of a well known State Senator. I have been subject to financial physical abusive, coercive control, and my child has been abused. The court system has been weaponized against us, and my 1 year old child unlawfully taken away. I was used for a [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I didn't learn about Judicial ethics in school, I learned about them in the Park County Courthouse. I learned that power without accountability and transparency is dangerous. When judges have personal relationships: business, family or professional and still sits on a case where [...]

— MANDY

My ex filed a motion to keep My kids from leaving the state then filed an ex parte emergency temporary full custody I had to leave the state where my kids live bc I couldn't afford to live on my own and had to get away from my ex the abuser. My lawyer won't fight for what I want [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Our nephews and niece have been removed from our care, and placed back into an extremely abusive home. Lots of new allegations of abuse.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

We are in constant worry mode for the safety of the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Jodi should be fired for all she has done to children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It destroyed me ruined my quality of life . The constant targeting has made me feel unsafe . And in constant worry for my children's safety. I miss my children so much. It's caused intense grief because of the intense powerlessness. I almost went to prison and I was all over the [...]

— TAMBI

Sucked into a system that never had the best interest of my children and. Left with lost time never to get back.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family. We went in with trust and came out with lost hope and dreams

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has utterly destroyed us. I left town and disappeared but I'm building my girls a homestead for their 18th birthday. They were 1 and 3 when they were stolen.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

For a year the children have been in reunification counseling with their dad. He has sat by while she decided to seperate them, threaten them, deny the abuse (proven) he had towards them and tell them I am a bad mother even though he went to rehab and gave me full custody after [...]

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“This case has devastated and traumatized my family in ways I cannot fully put into words, forcing me to watch my child suffer while I fought to be recognized as my child’s mother and the people in power ignored evidence, misstated facts, and treated my parental rights like they [...]

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05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *The court process has stripped us of the ability to live free, productive, joyful lives due to the cloud of stress and oppression ever looming and demanding more.*
>
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This system has ripped my family apart, and has done immeasurable damage. The time it will take to heal and finishing fixing what they have done, will take a lifetime.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Josh Van de Wetering , Adrienne Ellington and Brian Atcheson , supported false allegations in the family, civil, state and federal courtrooms until they were exposed for supporting perjury to harass families while benefiting to perpetuate harassment.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The systems allowing the violations of federal laws/icwa, my parental rights,ect but mostly caused mental harm to my family and self, my daughter's injuries in state care have caused trauma and anxiety in my daughter. Iv still never received any documents about my daughter's [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system falsely said that I was inappropriate with my daughter and denied my wife and I essential medical care. They used my father's false diagnosis of Alzheimer's to pin me for a mental illness because my ex wife was a nurse. They then took Alzheimer's off my father's [...]

— BRYAN

Instead of working together, lawyers and the family court has taken best friends and made us enemies. And the only one getting hurt is our daughter.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Mother has 74 failed mental health evaluations. I passed my one court ordered mental health evaluation, and my daughter was ripped from my arms.. when I had full custody mother was granted every weekend with her having full custody. I get the first and third weekend for [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Divide to conquer. Their overreach has to be stopped. They want to break the strongest bond in the world, between a mom and her kids. Its unconstitutional. It's sick.

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It has left one child disabled due to purjery and medical neglect and permanent memory loss; along with my other two children also experiencing medical and physical neglect.

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> *As torn me and my family apart has put a ton of pressure on my mom they've taken advantage of my Mom they're taking away my rights as a mother and I barely even get the time to call or talk to my daughter they have made every excuse in the book to keep me away from my daughter [...]*
>
> — KAYLE

The system stole time that can't be given back deprived of making memories that should of been remembered in stories later told that would help you feel sense of belonging, rooted with sense of family unity. Instead of feelings of loneliness worthlessness abandonment, looking [...]

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They have bypassed every guideline put into place to prevent third party take over. What they did was a**backwards. Amy Eddy. Failed our children. And she preaches she loves our constitution. Really?? Certainly not the part about parents and their children. And Marybeth Sampsel [...]

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Effectively torn my daughters from 4 generations of living families in mine and my ex husband's maternal side. .for political power and cult like control... Even school in Bigfork... Therapists .. I call those two .. theRAPISTS.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

37 Montana parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 37 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MONTANA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Montana families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> Hurt me and my children destroyed their lives and mine makes them live their abuser who made my son autistic
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> — BOBBIE

> Having to navigate a system where corrupt attorneys who play some sick game with your kids lives and to try and force a protective mother to bend to the will of a dangerous pedophile; a GAL hiding behind a psychologist degree who mocks and insults you and refused to follow the law of GAL investigating for the best interests of the children has been utter, bullshit! It should be obvious that a dangerous pedophile should not have any contact with children whether biological or not, and that these sicko attorneys arent following the law board rules
>
> — MARIAH

> Made me lose everything traumatized abused and neglected
>
> — LINDSEY

> I told the truth. I reported abuse to protect my sons and I. Now I only get supervised visits at the approval of our abuser.
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> — CHELSIE

> It has destroyed my mental Health. I have PTSD and CPTSD from domestic abuse as well as litigation, financial, and medical abuse. My records were published publicly as were my children's by the Court allowing others to misuse my records and data for further financial harm and legal proceedings. It has cost me my financial stability, income and ability to care for my medical needs and safety of me and my children and taken from my business.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

> By endorsing factually impossible recommendations and ignoring documented non-compliance, the current legal process has systematically deprived my children of stability and safety while allowing their developmental milestones to be traded for high-conflict trauma.
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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The father of my child is the son of a well known State Senator. I have been subject to financial physical abusive, coercive control, and my child has been abused. The court system has been weaponized against us, and my 1 year old child unlawfully taken away. I was used for a human breeder, and they are trying to discard me. I hear stories that I am not the first and will not be the last. I have went through over 80 attorneys explaining my case, no one will accept my case. There is no transparency, and transcripts are provided to me 30 days to months later, running the clock on appeals. The GAL was appointed by the abusers attorney and remains a permanent fixture and a tool for abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I didn't learn about Judicial ethics in school, I learned about them in the Park County Courthouse. I learned that power without accountability and transparency is dangerous. When judges have personal relationships: business, family or professional and still sits on a case where that connection exists...that's not a gray area. That's a line and it should not be crossed. People stop believing in justice because it looks like decisions are being made before a parent even walks into the room and silence where there should be disclosure. It looks like a system trying to protect itself...instead of protecting the people.

— MANDY

My ex filed a motion to keep My kids from leaving the state then filed an ex parte emergency temporary full custody I had to leave the state where my kids live bc I couldn't afford to live on my own and had to get away from my ex the abuser. My lawyer won't fight for what I want only what she thinks i will get or what the judge will agree too. I only get to see my kids once a month

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Our nephews and niece have been removed from our care, and placed back into an extremely abusive home. Lots of new allegations of abuse.

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We are in constant worry mode for the safety of the children.

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> "This case has devastated and traumatized my family in ways I cannot fully put into words, forcing me to watch my child suffer while I fought to be recognized as my child's mother and the people in power ignored evidence, misstated facts, and treated my parental rights like they did not matter. Instead of protecting my child and supporting reunification, the system created trauma, confusion, fear, and lasting damage to our bond, our peace, and our sense of safety and stability."
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> The court process has stripped us of the ability to live free, productive, joyful lives due to the cloud of stress and oppression ever looming and demanding more.
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> This system has ripped my family apart, and has done immeasurable damage. The time it will take to heal and finishing fixing what they have done, will take a lifetime.
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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system falsely said that I was inappropriate with my daughter and denied my wife and I essential medical care. They used my father's false diagnosis of Alzheimer's to pin me for a mental illness because my ex wife was a nurse. They then took Alzheimer's off my father's record and said he had Parkinson's due to his agent orange exposure. They mixed up my father and my medical records in the medical system and tried killing my current wife because she saw through the slander. They were prepared to let me die as well with a tumor in my spinal cord and hid it behind the false allegations of racism and discrimination. I am biracial as well with African American, Native American and Caucasian blood. I have been labeled as homophobic and other stuff as well while I was active duty in the USAF.

— BRYAN

Instead of working together, lawyers and the family court has taken best friends and made us enemies. And the only one getting hurt is our daughter.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

As torn me and my family apart has put a ton of pressure on my mom they've taken advantage of my Mom they're taking away my rights as a mother and I barely even get the time to call or talk to my daughter they have made every excuse in the book to keep me away from my daughter and my niece who is with my mom's care as well she is 7 years old and there is a 2 year old I have missed out on a couple different holidays so far and I've missed out on a ton of time and being involved with my daughter has taken a toll on my daughter a major toll and I can't get that time back let alone this damage is done to them during the time they were taken and put into foster care and without me being involved in their home it's been a huge change

— KAYLE

The system stole time that can't be given back deprived of making memories that should of been remembered in stories later told that would help you feel sense of belonging, rooted with sense of family unity. Instead of feelings of loneliness worthlessness abandonment, looking for brief comfort in drugs ECT after being deprived ability to give and receive love to rebuild strengthen parent/child relationships,

— HEATHER

They have bypassed every guideline put into place to prevent third party take over. What they did was a**backwards. Amy Eddy. Failed our children. And she preaches she loves our constitution. Really?? Certainly not the part about parents and their children. And Marybeth Sampsel Advocate for families?! That is a really cute way of saying predator.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Effectively torn my daughters from 4 generations of living families in mine and my ex husband's maternal side. .for political power and cult like control... Even school in Bigfork... Therapists .. I call those two .. theRAPISTS.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

37 full approved Montana comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Montana report comes from Montana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Montana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 75 Montana families reporting here are not the universe of Montana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – November 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.